

In my (biased) opinion, Emacs is like a Swiss army knife—it has so many functionalities that you don't use most of them. Vim is like a machete—just a single lethal blade. Again, my opinion is biased as I prefer Vim, and the one time I used Emacs was to use the org-mode. Soon, I felt that Emacs is too powerful and taxing my poor brain too much. In short, Emacs is complex but powerful, whereas Vim is simple and faster.

Now, let us try to identify the faction having an advantage in the editor war. Results from the Stack Overflow annual developer surveys are a good indicator of the popularity of a tool.

The annual surveys from 2016 to 2019 featured a question about popular development environments. Vim was preferred by about 25% of the respondents in these surveys, whereas less than 5% of the respondents preferred Emacs.

This seems like a clear lead. Thus, currently, the future of Vim looks more promising. Fig. 4 shows the logo of Vim.

Apache OpenOffice vs LibreOffice

If you have decided the Linux distro, the desktop environment, and the text editor for installation in your system, we can move on to the next essential software required—an office suite. Office suites typically include a word processor, spreadsheet program, presentation program, etc.

From 2001 to 2011, OpenOffice.org was the most popular open source office suite; it was supported by Sun Microsystems. When the latter was acquired by Oracle

Corporation in 2010, many of the contributors to the OpenOffice.org project felt that a fork was necessary.

The turbulent split of OpenOffice.org into LibreOffice and Apache OpenOffice is the reason for the



Fig. 5: LibreOffice logo

competition for dominance among office suites. Otherwise, the choice would have been obvious. This is also an ongoing war for dominance with no clear winner till date.

A point in favour of LibreOffice is that it has more frequent releases when compared with Apache OpenOffice. Another reason for LibreOffice having a slight upper hand over Apache OpenOffice is its look and feel. LibreOffice looks and feels more like Microsoft Office—the very popular proprietary office suite. This might be helpful to a person migrating from Microsoft Office. Fig. 5 shows the logo of LibreOffice.

Browser wars

The World Wide Web became very popular by the mid-1990s. The first browser war was between Internet Explorer and Netscape Navigator for dominance. In my opinion, this war ended in a catastrophe as both Netscape Navigator and Internet Explorer failed. Netscape Navigator had its final release in 2008 and Internet Explorer will be discontinued from 2022 onwards.

But the browser wars are not over yet. The second browser war is hotting up and is mainly being fought between Chrome, Safari, Edge, and Firefox. Though this is an ongoing war, the current strong contender is Chrome.

According to the latest stats by StatCounter (a popular Web traffic analysis website), Chrome

has over 60% market share among Web browsers. Safari and Edge are trailing far behind Chrome, and are placed in the second and third positions, respectively.

Notice that none of these Web browsers is fully open source. The truly open source Web browser Firefox is placed at the fourth position. Fig. 6 shows the logo of Firefox.

From the above discussion, it can be inferred that frequent forks and competition often negatively affect the adoption of open source



Fig. 6: Firefox logo

software and add to the confusion of a non-technical person planning to switch to Linux.

Before concluding, I would like to point out that I mostly use Fedora, KDE Plasma, Vim, LibreOffice, Chrome, etc, and my opinion might be biased. But the point I want to make is that the support for a particular software by the community is often very intense and switching of sides is rare.

So, if you haven't yet decided about the software you want to use, I think this might be a good time to do it. I believe you will be taken more seriously in the world of computing if you are an Ubuntu/GNOME/Vim/LibreOffice/Firefox sort of person than if you are a person indifferent to the software you work with. **EFY**

This article was first published in September 2021 issue of Open Source For You magazine